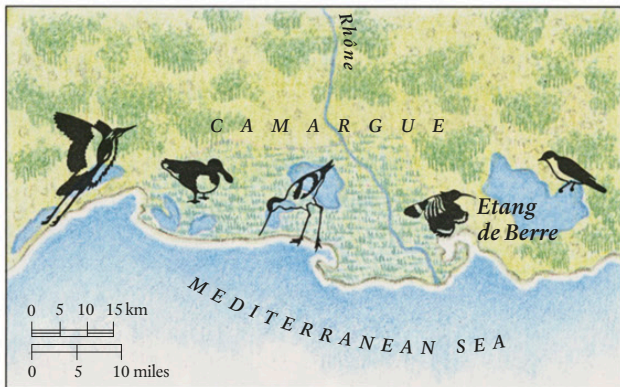


The Camargue

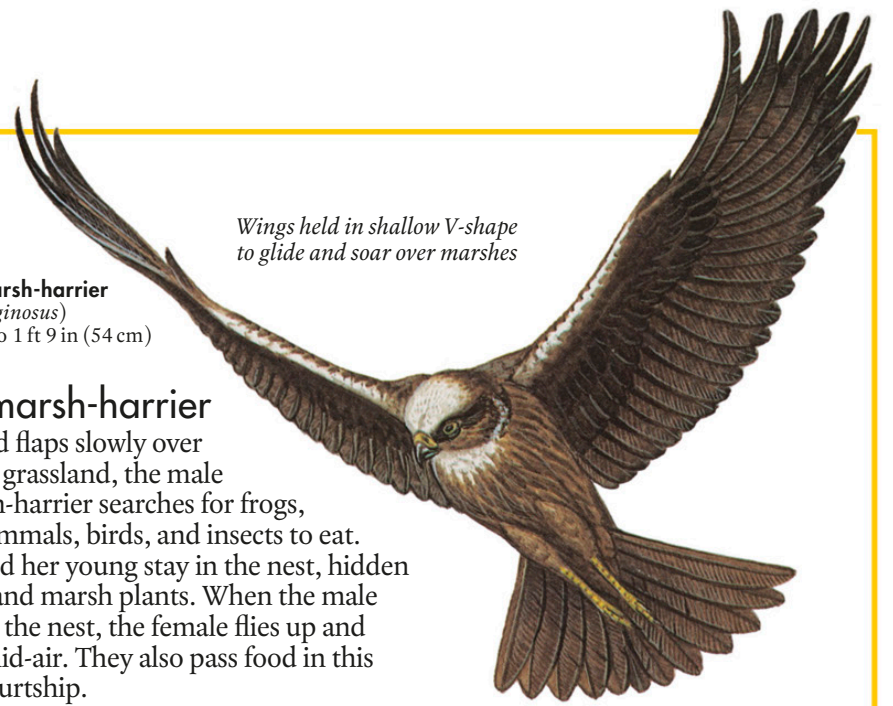
The salty marshes and shallow lakes of the Camargue nature reserve formed where the Rhône River meets the Mediterranean Sea. Despite people, houses, and industry all around and aircraft flying overhead, large numbers of wading birds and water birds live there, and even more pass through on their migration routes. Tens of thousands of swans, ducks, and geese visit the Camargue in winter from their breeding grounds in northern Europe and Siberia. The birds share the available food by feeding in different places and on different types of food: stilts feed in shallow water while little egrets and purple herons prefer deeper water; herons catch fish, while spoonbills, flamingos, and avocets feed on small water creatures.



Western marsh-harrier
(*Circus aeruginosus*)
Length: up to 1 ft 9 in (54 cm)

Western marsh-harrier

As it glides and flaps slowly over reed beds and grassland, the male western marsh-harrier searches for frogs, fish, small mammals, birds, and insects to eat. The female and her young stay in the nest, hidden among reeds and marsh plants. When the male brings food to the nest, the female flies up and catches it in mid-air. They also pass food in this way during courtship.



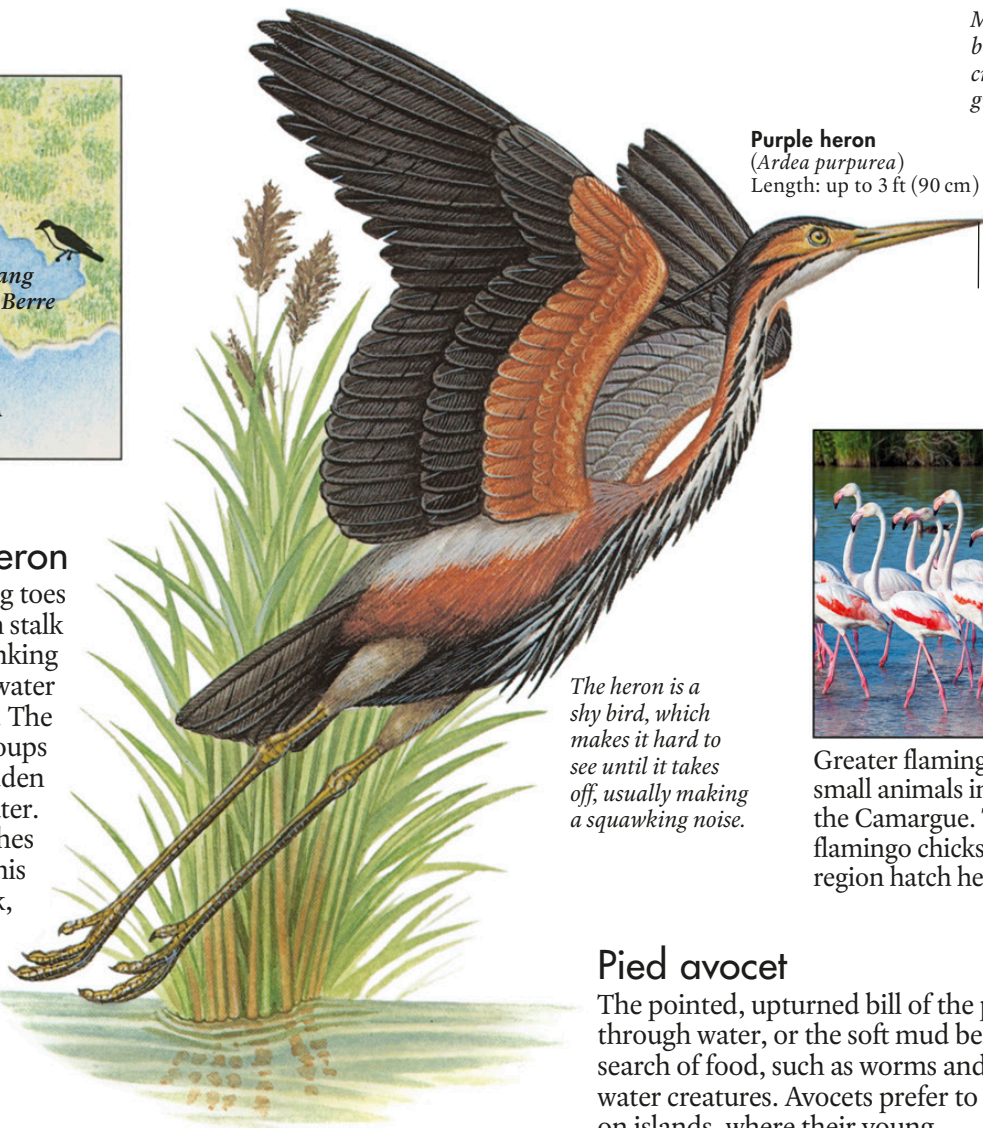
Wings held in shallow V-shape to glide and soar over marshes

Males and females are both brown, but females have a light-colored crown, and adult males have some gray in their wings.

Purple heron
(*Ardea purpurea*)
Length: up to 3 ft (90 cm)

Very sharp, pointed bill to grab fish and frogs

Purple heron
The tall, slender purple heron has long toes to spread out its weight so that it can stalk over floating marsh plants without sinking in. Its long legs let it wade into deep water where it fishes for food with its long bill. The purple heron usually nests in small groups of up to 20 pairs. The nests are hidden among reeds or rushes in shallow water. When alarmed, the purple heron crouches with its bill pointing straight up. This pose, along with the stripes on its neck, make it hard to see among the reeds.



The heron is a shy bird, which makes it hard to see until it takes off, usually making a squawking noise.

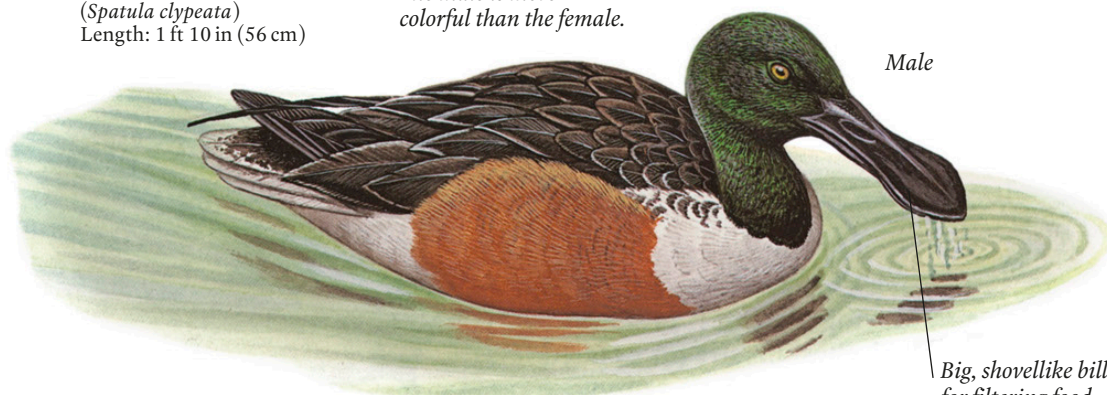


Greater flamingos feed on plants and small animals in the shallow waters of the Camargue. Three-quarters of all the flamingo chicks in the Mediterranean region hatch here.

Northern shoveler
(*Spatula clypeata*)
Length: 1 ft 10 in (56 cm)

The male is more colorful than the female.

Male



Big, shovellike bill for filtering food from water.

Northern shoveler

This bird, which spends its winters in the Mediterranean basin, gets its name from its shovel-shaped bill. At first, the chick has a normal bill, but this changes as it grows up. The adult shoveler sucks water into its wide bill and then pushes it out of the sides. Fine "combs" on the inside edges of the bill trap tiny floating animals and plants from the water as it flows over them.

Pied avocet

The pointed, upturned bill of the pied avocet sweeps through water, or the soft mud beneath it, in search of food, such as worms and small water creatures. Avocets prefer to nest on islands, where their young are safer from attack. They usually nest in large colonies so they can join forces against predators.

Pied avocet
(*Recurvirostra avosetta*)
Length: 1 ft 6 in (45 cm)

Long legs and long bill for feeding in deep water

